INDIA@PARIS 2024

LIFTING A NATION'S HOPES

MIRABAI CHANU, 29

Sport: ***WEIGHTLIFTING*** *49 KG*

Achievement: **Silver at the 2020 Olympics**

How she qualified: **Lifted 184 kg at the IWF World Cup in Phuket in April**



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IN 2021, battling menstrual cramps, she had lifted the burden of an entire nation's expectations at the Tokyo Olympics and given the medal-parched country a silver. A year later, though, she had trouble lifting her own body weight of 49 kg. As Mirabai stared at a wheelchair-bound future, the country moved on to pin its hopes on other medal prospects for the 2024 Paris Games. But Mirabai is having none of it, as she prepares to change the script by the dint of sheer will and determination.

Pain has been a constant companion in Mirabai's decade-long career, be it injury in the lower back, shoulder or wrist. Days before the 2022 World Championships in Bogota, Mirabai injured her wrist, but went on to win a silver (her second World medal) despite the pain, looking well on course for Paris. However, at the 2023 Hangzhou Asian Games, she hurt her hip during the competition. "The pain was excruciating. I couldn't even do free squats. I wasn't sure if the pain would subside with rest. My mind was clouded with so many questions," Mirabai Chanu told INDIA TODAY from Paris where she has moved to acclimatise to the conditions. Out of action for five months, she made yet another comeback at the World Cup in Phuket in April, lifting a total of 184 kg for a third place and a berth in Paris.

Just weeks ahead of the Olympics, Mirabai is yet to go full throttle with her training but says coach Vijay Sharma has it all planned. "I am at my 100 per cent. In Patiala (Olympics camp), I pushed myself to 80-85 per cent of my usual load...here in Paris, we will go all-out," says the diminutive weightlifter. That means lifting more than 200 kg for a medal in the midst of a tough field where at least four lifters will be vying to do the same.

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In Tokyo, Mirabai had flaunted her customised Olympic earrings. After the silver, she rewarded herself with a tattoo. "In Manipuri, we refer to our mother as 'Eema'. I got it tattooed on my forearm," she says. As she prepares for her third Olympic and second medal, the nation can't wait to see what the girl with the Eema tattoo will do. ■

–Rahul Rawat